Free Public Real Estate Data Research Checklist

Version 0.6 | 2026-11-01 | Educational / research only. Free public sources. Compliance-first. Not advice.

Pre-Flight
- Confirm only free, publicly accessible sources (official .gov preferred).
- No paid API keys required for basic research.
- Document source URL and access date for every data point.
- Respect robots.txt and terms of use.
- Note data freshness (assessor data often lags).

Step 1: Identify Location
- Obtain full address or ZIP.
- Free Census Geocoder: https://geocoding.geo.census.gov/geocoder/geographies/address
- Note county, FIPS, tract.

Step 2: County Property Records
Examples of free public access:
- King County WA, Maryland SDAT, LA County, Cook County IL.
- Search "[County] [State] assessor property search".
- Retrieve assessed value, tax, type, sq ft, year built, last sale if public.

Step 3: Census Demographics
- https://data.census.gov — ACS 5-year: income, housing, median value.
- Free API optional at api.census.gov.

Step 4: Flood & Hazard
- FEMA MSC: https://msc.fema.gov/portal/home

Step 5: Additional Free Sources
- HUD User FY2026 FMRs free.
- FHFA HPI.
- Freddie Mac PMMS educational rates only: as of 2026-10-29 (unchanged as of 2026-11-01 check), 30-year fixed 7.24%, 15-year 6.60%. Next release expected Thursday. Not a quote.
- OpenAddresses.

Step 6: Compile & Document
- One-page summary with sources and dates.
- Flag any login/payment requirements (do not use).

Status: Free draft. No revenue. For potential digital product after real buyer interest.